For Burnes it was all over: Vitkevitch had won. There was now no longer any point in the Scotsman prolonging his stay in Kabul. On 25 April he and Dost Mohammad exchanged sad notes of farewell to each other. The following morning Burnes, Mohan Lal and Masson rode out of Kabul. Masson wrote that the sudden departure of the British 'partook a little of the nature of flight', and Maulana Hamid Kashmiri in his *Akbarnama* actually has Burnes fleeing for his life:

> His cheeks became yellow like saffron
> Inwardly he gave up his life
>
> The Amir said: 'Up and out with you! Fly from this place!
> Set out on your journey with all haste
>
> Lest in your greed for money and treasure
> You get from me suffering and punishment
>
> I fear that contrary to what one may think
> Great affliction will fall upon you
>
> I see it as very far from my principles
> To kill someone after showing favour
>
> I do not wish to lose my honour for gold
> By handing a guest of mine over to another'
> Sikandar [Burnes,] who had no hope of life
> Could not have imagined such a deliverance
>
> He set out from Kabul upon the road to Hind
> Like a sheep running away from a roaring lion
> Every step of the way he would look back
> Lest the falcon should seize him again[104]

In reality, it was not quite as bad as Afghan hindsight remembered it. The British were escorted out of town by the Amir's youngest son, Ghulam Haidar Khan, and as a last gesture of personal friendship Dost Mohammad sent Mirza Sami Khan with three stallions which reached the party at the village of Butkhak, twelve miles from Kabul. Burnes and Dost Mohammad would not meet again for another three years, and when they did so it would be under very different circumstances.

Before Jalalabad, Burnes boarded a raft which would take him down the Kabul River to Peshawar. By this stage Vitkevitch was already well on his